Witnessing & trauma

A participant remembers

1 Remains: the idea

Armitage's soldier recalls a shared shooting, then cannot escape it at home. Uncertainty about the man's weapon persists.

The mark on the road becomes a mental presence. War imagery relocates the conflict inside his head.

2 Remains: the method

Colloquial dramatic monologue; enjambment drives the account. Shared pronouns narrow towards isolated responsibility; final couplet concentrates it.

Veterans' testimony informed The Not Dead. The poetic speaker is not Armitage himself.

A witness records

3 War Photographer: the idea

Human suffering → Selected image

Selected image → Viewer response

Duffy's photographer develops film while painful memories return. A few published images receive a brief response.

Religious imagery makes his task solemn. Domestic safety contrasts with suffering he witnessed.

4 War Photographer: the method

Four sestets with ABBCDD rhyme impose order beside emotional disturbance. The ending resumes the work cycle.

Film darkroom and newspaper culture shape the ethical problem. Professional composure can coexist with distress.

An observer reconsiders

5 Decomposition: the idea

Ghose's speaker re-examines a photograph of a sleeping beggar in Bombay. Earlier pride becomes shame about turning hardship into art.

Stone imagery seems to erase individuality; the poem then challenges that way of seeing.

6 Decomposition: the method

Five quatrains in free verse. Past confidence changes to present self-criticism. The beggar is asleep, not confirmed dead.

Compare photographer, subject and viewer responsibilities. Duffy questions the audience; Ghose also questions the image-maker.